



“The streaming started when I saw 70,000 people watching the final. It was incredible, the passion of the people”

SRINATH NARAYANAN
GRANDMASTER



“There is this serious image attached to chess. But seeing chess players have fun has made it more approachable”

TANIA SACHDEV
INTERNATIONAL MASTER & WOMAN GRANDMASTER



“Our vision is to grow chess. The money will follow if we direct our energy in growing the sport”

SAGAR SHAH
INTERNATIONAL MASTER,
CO-FOUNDER & CEO,
CHESSBASE INDIA

subcontinent, the roots of the game are lost in the sands of time. But that has not prevented the game from cultivating a loyal fan base in the country. “You now have people who are watching people play chess. They love it when you play tournaments; they are connected with you. It has definitely become something that everyone enjoyed, but there was this catalyst that was required to make it into a more mainstream thing. Everyone knew about chess, but people were almost scared to play. It can be very intimidating. But now, once you get into it, people are just addicted to the game,” is how Sachdev puts it.

Although live streaming of chess games is in its infancy in India, it presents a lot of opportunity for growth in terms of streaming official tournaments, sponsorship deals, covering and reviewing professional matches, engaging with viewers, subscribers and the players themselves. Says Ashish Pherwani, EY India Media & Entertainment Leader: “Unlike broadcast that only allows content with mass appeal, streaming allows for content with a niche appeal to find a home and get distributed, and chess fits into that. It’s not a mass sport, it is extremely

intellectual but it has a dedicated following. Streaming of chess games provides for a kind of lower cost, lower reach model but a very dedicated fan base of people watching.”

In the same vein, Sagar Shah, an IM and Co-founder & CEO of ChessBase India, continues that although he started the company in 2017 with the intention of supporting the game’s growth in India, its business, too, has grown substantially over time. He adds that when they started, there was no fixed revenue model apart from the fact that ChessBase software brought in inflow whereby they could keep going and maintain the website.

“Our revenue sources are divided into the sale of products and the media-related activities that we do. But from the perspective of cashing in, we are very careful. Our vision is to grow chess and make it the most popular sport in the country. The money will follow if we direct our energy in growing the sport.”

But the financial aspect of the game is not what keeps driving the community of chess players and audience into each other’s arms. Rather, it is the thrill of watching the very serious and competitive professional

chess players let their hair down and blow off some steam while engaged in a friendly joust against peers.

For example, in the stream described above, the true colour of the players’ intentions are revealed when Gujrathi takes Botez’s Queen with his Queen and Giri takes one of her Pawns with his Queen. In turn, she takes Gujrathi’s Queen with her Knight, and Giri and Gujrathi try to cajole Agadmator to go after Botez’s pieces, which will eliminate her from the game. Agadmator says if he does that, he will be left to fight two GMs alone, which doesn’t seem like such a good idea. The alliance between the GMs comes to an abrupt halt as Agadmator refuses to checkmate Gujrathi’s King, which gives Gujrathi an opportunity to take Giri’s Queen.

The live stream goes on like this for another hour with many a thrust and parry of pieces moved forward to attack or pulled back to defend, and as the game ends with Giri eliminated first, followed by Botez, all the players agree that a rematch is in order since they were not very familiar with the format. And, so it goes again! **BT**